

WHAT PERIOD BLOOD COLOUR & FLOW CAN TELL YOU

Menstrual blood can vary in colour, flow, and timing throughout a cycle. These changes are usually normal and are part of how the body sheds the uterine lining each month. Paying attention to these patterns can help people better understand their menstrual health.

It is important to remember that period blood colour alone is not usually a sign of a health problem. Healthcare providers usually look at broader patterns such as cycle timing, heaviness of bleeding, pain, and other symptoms when evaluating menstrual health.

Why Period Blood Changes Colour

Period blood may appear in different colours because of how long the blood remains in the uterus before leaving the body.

When blood is exposed to oxygen, a process called oxidation occurs, which makes it appear darker over time. As a result, menstrual blood can naturally shift from lighter shades to darker shades during the course of a period.

Common Period Blood Colours

Pink

- Often appears at the beginning or end of a period
- Can happen when a small amount of blood mixes with cervical fluid
- May also occur when menstrual flow is very light

Bright Red

- Usually seen during the heavier days of a period
- Indicates fresh blood leaving the uterus quickly
- Has had little time to oxidize

Dark Red

- May appear later in the menstrual cycle
- Happens when blood remains in the uterus slightly longer
- Small clots may also appear during heavier flow days, which is often normal

Brown

- Usually appears toward the end of a period
- Often represents older blood that has oxidized more before leaving the body

Menstrual Flow Patterns

Menstrual flow can vary widely between individuals. Some people experience lighter periods, while others have heavier bleeding. Occasional changes in flow are usually not a concern, but it is important to notice patterns over time.

Healthcare providers may investigate menstrual changes such as:

- Bleeding that is extremely heavy
- Periods lasting longer than about 7 days
- Periods occurring very frequently
- Skipping several months without a period
- Severe pain during menstruation

These symptoms may sometimes be related to hormonal changes or conditions affecting the uterus.

When to Seek Medical Advice

It is recommended to consult a healthcare provider if menstrual changes are persistent or interfere with daily life.

Medical advice should be sought if someone experiences:

- Very heavy bleeding
- Large blood clots
- Severe pelvic pain
- Bleeding between periods
- Sudden major changes in cycle timing

Healthcare professionals can help determine whether these changes are normal variations or signs of an underlying condition.

Key Takeaway

Menstrual blood can appear in several colours throughout a cycle, including pink, red, dark red, and brown. These changes are usually related to blood flow and oxidation rather than health problems.

Instead of focusing only on colour, it is more helpful to monitor overall menstrual patterns such as timing, flow, and symptoms. Understanding these patterns can help individuals make informed decisions about their reproductive health.

Bloom provides educational guidance only. Always consult with a qualified healthcare professional for personalized medical advice.

Educational content informed by Cleveland Clinic. (2025). Period blood comes in different colors: Here's what they mean. Northwestern Medicine. (2021). What your period says about your health: Flow, color, timing and more.